

JOHN W. BARRY

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ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Rice University, Jones Graduate School of Business	Houston, TX
Assistant Professor of Finance	2024-

EDUCATION

Duke University, Fuqua School of Business	Durham, NC
PhD, Finance	2018-2024
Barcelona School of Economics	Barcelona, Spain
MS, International Trade, Finance and Development (ITFD)	2015-2016
Trinity College Dublin	Dublin, Ireland
BA, Philosophy, Politics, Economics & Sociology (PPES)	2009-2013

WORKING PAPERS

Shareholder Voice and Executive Compensation

Job market paper (November 2024) [Latest version, SSRN](#)

I estimate a model of CEO compensation with non-binding shareholder approval votes (Say-on-Pay). The Board sets pay and may be biased toward high pay; shareholders can fail the vote and punish the Board for overpayment. I estimate that failed votes are costly to both parties. Say-on-Pay resembles a costly punishment mechanism: its disciplining effect raises firm value by 2.4% on average, despite only 7% of votes failing. I analyze a counterfactual binding Say-on-Pay: vote failure fixes CEO pay to its previous level, which may not reflect current information about CEO skill. The vote failure rate falls, pay levels increase and firm value decreases.

Human Capital, Competition and Mobility in the Managerial Labor Market

with Noah Lyman and Lin Zhao (November 2024)

We estimate a search model of managerial careers to quantify the relative importance of human capital accumulation (both general and firm-specific), managerial bargaining power, and imperfect labor market competition in shaping compensation and mobility in the market for US corporate executives. The composition of human capital is career-dependent and varies widely across managers: over tenure, firm-specific capital is the greatest driver of wage growth, whereas over experience in the labor market, job search and competition dominate. Firm-specific capital can help explain the high rate of internal CEO hires and low observed cross-firm CEO mobility. We further show that labor market competition (relative to pure bargaining power) makes up the majority of realized CEO surplus capture, and that firm-specific human capital positively interacts with competition in determining CEOs' shares of rents because it raises the match-specific quality between the firm and manager.

Sacred Hurdle Rates and Bargaining Power

with Bruce Carlin, Alan Crane and John Graham (March 2024) [SSRN](#)

CFOs report using buffered hurdle rates that average 6.6 percentage points above the cost of capital. These are taken at face value by managers (considered sacred) and are a focus of firm activity: realized returns in our data cluster just above elevated hurdle rates. Buffers convey an added bargaining advantage over counterparties during project development and M&A activity. In a model, we show that this benefit can exceed the opportunity cost of forgone projects, thus preserving firm value. Consistent with the model, M&A transactions with elevated bidder hurdle rates are associated with higher surplus capture ex post. Also, in CFO survey data, buffers are negatively related to ex ante bargaining power.

PUBLICATIONS

Corporate Flexibility in a Time of Crisis

with Murillo Campello, John Graham and Yueran Ma (June 2022)

[Journal of Financial Economics](#)

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

- 2024:** Toulouse School of Economics, CEMFI, Cornell University, Notre Dame University, Rice University, Ohio State University, UMass Amherst, MIT Sloan, Boston College, University of Maryland, Vanderbilt University, UVA Darden, MFA, Eastern Finance, Aarhus Strategic Interactions Workshop, Lone Star Finance Symposium, UTD Finance Conference, Southwestern Finance Conference[†]
- 2023:** AFA, LBS TADC, Inter-Finance PhD Seminar, Duke IO lunch, Fuqua, Olin Finance Conference PhD Poster Session, Boca Finance Conference
- 2020-2022:** AFA, ITAM Finance Conference, Fuqua (×3) [†] = scheduled

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor	Rice University
Advanced Corporate Finance (Undergraduate)	2025-
Advanced Corporate Finance (Evening MBA)	2025-
Head Teaching Assistant	Duke University
Corporate Finance (MBA)	2019-2023
Empirical Methods in Corporate Finance (PhD)	2019-2023
Pre-PhD	International House Dublin & Huelva
English Teacher	2013-2015

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Python, Julia, R, SQL, Stata, SAS, Git, SLURM

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

Referee: American Economic Review: Insights, Journal of Human Capital, Management Science, Financial Management, Journal of Corporate Finance